

The Manasseh Hill Country Survey

Volume IV: From Nahal Bezeq to the Sartaba

By

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B. THE GEOGRAPHY OF THE SOUTHERN JORDAN VALLEY AND THE SARTABA DISTRICT

1. *Boundaries*

The boundaries of the landscape units of Volume 4 complement those of Volume 2 of this Survey.

Throughout this volume the River Jordan is **the eastern boundary** of the area: The main features in the southern Jordan Valley (between Beit She'an and the Dead Sea) are the *Zor* (the lower strip of land close to the River Jordan) and the *Ghor*. A security fence was erected in the *Zor* in the early 1970s, stretching along the entire length of the border between Israel and Jordan, hampering and almost preventing the research of the strip next to the river. This strip is 500-700 m wide in the Beit She'an and Jordan valleys, and more than 3 km wide in the vicinity of the Nahal Tirzah reserve, in the east opposite the Sartaba. On several occasions we tried to survey some of the area and sites there, but we were only partially successful.

The northern boundary passes along Nahal Bezeq (Wadi Shubash). This stream divides the Beit She'an Valley into two: the larger part (about two-thirds) in the north, and the small one to the south. The two parts are very similar, but the Survey required a northern border.

The western boundary is the eastern boundary of Volume 2 of the Survey, and at the same time the topographical border between the Jordan Valley and the fringes of Samaria. At the north-west the border runs along the ridges of 'Iraq el-Hamam and Wadi Ha'shneh. From there, along the Bardaleh-Mehola road, it continues south-east to the ridge of Ra'us ej-Jibsin. From here the border turns south to the west of the Beit She'an-Jericho road (the Jordan Valley road). This road lies on the line between the desert fringes and the narrow strip of the flat Jordan Valley. After it reaches the Nahal Tirzah floodplain, the border turns west, and then south-east. It passes the southern foot of Ras el-Kharubeh to the narrow pass of the Shechem-Jiftlik road (Bab ed-Dayyq).

The Sartaba range protrudes westward further than the other three landscape units. This is a mountainous unit enclosed on all sides. Part of its border is the road south from the Hamra Junction (the 'Alon road'). In the north-west the border runs along the Alon road to Mehora, and from there south to Gittit and Maale Ephraim. From Maale Ephraim **the southern border** of the area in this volume descends eastward in Wadi Zamour and Wadi Ahmar until it reaches the Fasaal junction, from where it goes east to the River Jordan.

The total area of the four landscape units included in this volume is 250 sq. km.

2. *Geology and Geomorphology*

A. The southern Jordan Valley and Beit She'an Valley. The nature of the Jordan Valley, which is a part of the Syrian-African Rift, has great influence upon the settlement data contained in this volume. This rift, stretching for nearly 3000 km from eastern Turkey to East Africa, is a deep rupture in the crust of the Earth. The chronology and how it was formed are a subject for debate (Ilan 1973: 13-14). As to the time of its formation, there are at least three opinions. Several researchers are of the opinion that it was created by vertical tectonic movement. Others, who link it to the movements of continents, speak of horizontal fracturing. It is also possible that the Jordan Depression had split into a northern system (from Mount Hermon to Beit She'an) and southern one (from Beit She'an to the Arabah) during the Neogene. The considerable subsequent erosion partially filled up the riverbeds, including that of the Jordan, with alluvium. At the end of the Neogene or beginning of the Pleistocene, tectonic activity restarted, accompanied by erosion. This created the large alluvial fans – the Beit She'an Valley and the deltas (floodplains) of Nahal Tirzah and Wadi Ahmar. Lakes, which later dried up, developed over these fans during the Lower Pleistocene.

At the end of the Pliocene, some three million years ago, the Jordan Depression was connected to the Mediterranean and was flooded by sea-water. During



6. The chalky cliff of the *Ghor* and the *Zor* at its foot, view to the south, 2002 (M. Einav).

the following slow drying process, chalk, gypsum and various salts were deposited in the Beit She'an Valley. At the end of the Pleistocene the seas became disconnected, creating Lake Lisan, filling the whole Jordan Valley from the Sea of Galilee to Hatzeva in the Arabah. At the peak of the rainy period (about 25000 years BP) the lake's surface reached its highest level – about 180 m below sea level. Lake Lisan was salty and was connected to smaller secondary lakes. It is possible to trace this stage by the terraces of the lakeshore. The drying and retreat of the lake resulted in the creation of the *Ghor*. At the end of the process (some 15000 years BP), the drying of Lake Lisan left two residual lakes – the Sea of Galilee and the Dead Sea.

The River Jordan was created when water gushed out from the Sea of Galilee, and cut a chanel along the bottom of Lake Lisan. The river cut a meandering channel because of the very gentle gradient. The process began 12000 years ago in the Holocene and has continued until now. At the margins of Lake Lisan the streams continued to cut into the alluvium fans and the *Ghor*, creating today's typical transected landscape.

According to Nir (1962a: 102) the western upper level of the *Ghor* in the Beit She'an Valley is made of chalky tuff and chalky sediments of ancient lakes. The surface level of the *Ghor* appearing further east is made of Lisan marl – a lake sediment from the Mid-Quaternary. The *Zor* is made of alluvial soil brought by the river. South of it, in the vicinity of Nahal Bezeq, the moderate slope descends from the Gilboa to the Jordan, containing various alluvium fans of wadis.

B. The narrow Jordan Valley. From the vicinity of Meḥola southwards the Jordan Valley becomes very narrow. The region contains the eastern Samaria Mountains, descending steeply to the Jordan depression, as part of the Far'ah anticline (about this anticline and its formation, see a summary of an article by Meimran 1992, in Zertal 2008: 17-18). The fault system of eastern Samaria is orientated from north-west to south-east. These faults created the horsts (raised blocks of land) of Jebel Kebir, Jebel Ṭammun and Ras Jadir, which reach the Jordan depression. To the grabens (depressed blocks of land) belong (from south to north) Nahal Tirzah, the Buqe'ah and Wadi Maliḥ. Another part of this region is the *Ghor* and the *Zor*, discussed above.

C. The delta of Nahal Tirzah is a relatively young alluvium fan between the hard limestone of Ras el-Kharubeh and the Sartaba range. The fan is covered by a mixture of Mediterranean brown forest soils, rendzinas and terra rossa. This mixture is well suited for cultivation, and is relatively rich in organic matter.

D. The Sartaba range is a plateau of Eocene rock along the Jordan Valley, a southern section of the eastern Samaria range (Binyamini 1984: 8). The Sartaba is located on the lowest of the three tiers descending from the Samaria watershed to the Jordan Valley. The highest tier is situated on the Samaria watershed;

on the middle tier are located the villages of Kh. Yannun, 'Aqraba, Duma and Majdal Bani-Fadel; and the lowest tier (Mekhora, Gittit, Maale Ephraim) has fertile valleys. The Sartaba range rises to the east of the lower tier. It is a horst of soft rock, raised by a series of parallel geological faults. The considerable elevation differences (about 700 m – from 377 m a.s.l. at the top of the Sartaba cone down to 300 m b.s.l. in the Jordan Valley) caused especially severe erosion of the Sartaba slopes, and created the elevated formation of the horst. The Sartaba range is built of Eocene rock containing four formations: Zora, Nitzana, Horsha and Matred (Binyamini 1984: 8).

3. Climate, Water, Soil and Vegetation

Climate

The various districts have different climates. Beit She'an's climate is characterized by the transformation from the semi-arid climate in the north to a desertic (arid – Irano-Turanian) one in the south in the borderland of Samaria. The droughts here are relatively frequent, and therefore irrigated agriculture is customary (Nir 1962b). The average annual precipitation in the south of the valley is 288 mm, but the divergence from the average reaches 41%. The rainy season is lengthy, and the rain falls in brief and torrential showers (for example – two showers of 60 mm, lasting 35 minutes – Nir 1962a: 103). The temperatures are also noted for their extremes.

Further south, in the delta of Nahal Tirzah and the Sartaba range, steppe-like weather prevails, and the phytogeography is Irano-Turanian. In these districts the summer is long and hot with a steady wind regime along the valleys. The winter is moderate, with lower temperatures and little precipitation. The precipitation distribution through the year and between years is uneven (Katzanelson 1966: 51-62).

Water sources

There is a great difference between the Beit She'an Valley and other districts. In the south of the Valley (Landscape Unit 27) there are many water sources, most of them layer springs. We have counted 13 such springs: Mehazzim, Tzafot, 'Ein Ibrahim, 'Ein Muqehaz, 'Ein Bardaleh, 'Araq, 'Ein el-Bedha, 'Ein Buleibil, 'Ein Qurein, 'Ein Shams, Hammeh, Safsafa and 'Ein Sakut. The majority are on the eastern side of the region, and are or were the sources of streams, used mainly for irrigation.

The springs in the west (Qa'un, Bardaleh, 'Araq and Hammeh) emerge from above the Cenozoic aquifer in the seam between the mountains in the west and the floodplain of the Valley in the east. Settlements and/or multi-stratum tells developed close to most of them.

Knowledge of the influence of the many springs in the area is essential for understanding its history. Unlike other districts of Samaria, irrigated agriculture in the Beit She'an Valley evolved during very ancient times. Despite the fact that this issue has not been fully investigated, it can be assumed that small-scale irrigated agriculture already existed in the area in the Chalcolithic period. The relationship of the advanced Byzantine watering systems to those of preceding periods has not been clarified: was it irrigation with trenches, as in Egypt and Mesopotamia, or was it simply flooding irrigation? This issue requires additional research, but the link between the springs and the sites is clear.

The rather modest precipitation in the Jordan Valley, together with the inconsistency of the rains and the occurrence of floods, increased human dependence on reliable water sources (Bonne and Buydah 1977). In Landscape Unit 28, the narrow Jordan Valley, there are almost no flowing water sources. Along the 24 km of the narrow strip, there are only three small sources, at the edge of the *Ghor*: 'Ein Juneidiyeh, 'Ein Saleh and 'Ein Abu Sidreh. These are very small layer springs, with small-scale settlements nearby. In the Nahal Tirzah floodplain, Landscape Unit 29, there was an advanced channel irrigation system, and it seems that the whole area was irrigated. This system was noted by the Moslem traveller Yakut, who described cultivation of sugar cane in the Valley in Medieval times; and by travellers and researchers from the 19th and 20th centuries. The Ottoman (or earlier) aqueduct in Sheikh Mazar (Site



7. 'Ein Hāfireh spring south-east of the Sartaba, 1999 (R. Be'eri).

82) could have irrigated the entire western upper part of the delta, and it seems that similar aqueducts existed to the north of the riverbed.

The use of water from the Jordan for human consumption over the ages raises a question. The bed of the Jordan in the *Zor* is below the level of the surrounding area, and it seems that aqueducts did not exist along its course. The frequent changes in the course of the Jordan, due to its very slight slope, also made the use of aqueducts impractical. The presence and area of agricultural land along the Jordan during ancient times were not investigated because of the uncertain state of security and the minefields. The maps and the few earlier surveys in the region indicate very few tells in the *Zor* itself. Such tells have been found only at the south of the Beit She'an Valley (Tell Jima'in, Tel Tzaf and Tell Abu Sus). Further south, only Tell Abu Sidreh, located in the *Zor* close to the Jordan, is noteworthy. The eastern side of the Jordan Valley, especially the valley of Sukkot, is much richer in water sources and soil than the western side, hence the scarcity of tells on the western side and their abundance on the eastern side. Habitation was always concentrated on the eastern side, helped by the absence of political frontiers between east and west.

The mountainous land-block of the Sartaba is surrounded by several springs with medium or low flows, mostly on its eastern and western sides. In the east is 'Ein Jeruzaliyeh; and in the west 'Ein Abu Daraj, Hafireh and 'Ein el-Mana. Most of the approach roads to the Sartaba developed near these springs, beginning in the Iron Age.

The soil

The types of soil are categorised according to the landscape units (for general review see Dan 1977):

1. The south of the Beit She'an Valley is covered by a mixture of alluvial soil with remnants of Holocene lake soils (Ilan 1973: 48). The area of the valley next to the Jordan is covered with sedimentary Lisan marl, rich in gypsum and salt. This soil is poor in organic matter, and is not very fertile. The agricultural wealth of the district relies more on spring water than soil fertility.
2. The soils of the narrow Jordan Valley and Nahal Tirzah's flood plain are a mixture of rendzinas, washed-out desert and colluvial-alluvial soils.

In the high *Ghor* and in the *Zor* there are concentrations of gypsum and salt in the Lisan marls, causing the formation of saline flats (*sabkhas*) in the Nahal Tirzah floodplain. Brown forest soils from the desert fringes of Samaria are washed out and accumulate in the alluvial fans. These are fairly fertile soils, in which wheat and other seasonal crops are grown.

Date stones found in the Teleilat Ghassul excavations prove that date palms were already cultivated in the *Ghor* in the Chalcolithic period (Levy 1993: 509). The epithet 'The Valley of Jericho, City of Dates' (Deut 34: 3) shows that cultivation of date palms was common in the Iron Age. Vast groves of date palms and persimmon (*Diospyros kaki*) were grown in the Lisan marl soils of the Jordan Valley in the Roman period (War I, xviii: 5).

Vegetation

Zohary (1980: 186-190) divides Samaria into two phyto-geographical districts: Mediterranean and savannah-like (Irano-Turanian). Damin (1970) divides eastern Samaria into three longitudinal strips and four main plant communities. Based upon the work of Berliner (1978) and Sabah (1992), the landscape units of this volume may be classified as follows:

The Beit She'an Valley, the narrow strip of the Jordan Valley (Landscape Unit 28) and the alluvium fan of Nahal Tirzah belong to the tropical enclaves with Sudanese-Dicakan vegetation (Zohary 1955; 1980: 187). These are districts with high temperatures and flowing water, dominated by Jericho Balsam (*Balanites aegyptiaca*), Common Jujube (*Ziziphus spina-christi*) and Sodom Apple (*Calotropis procera*).

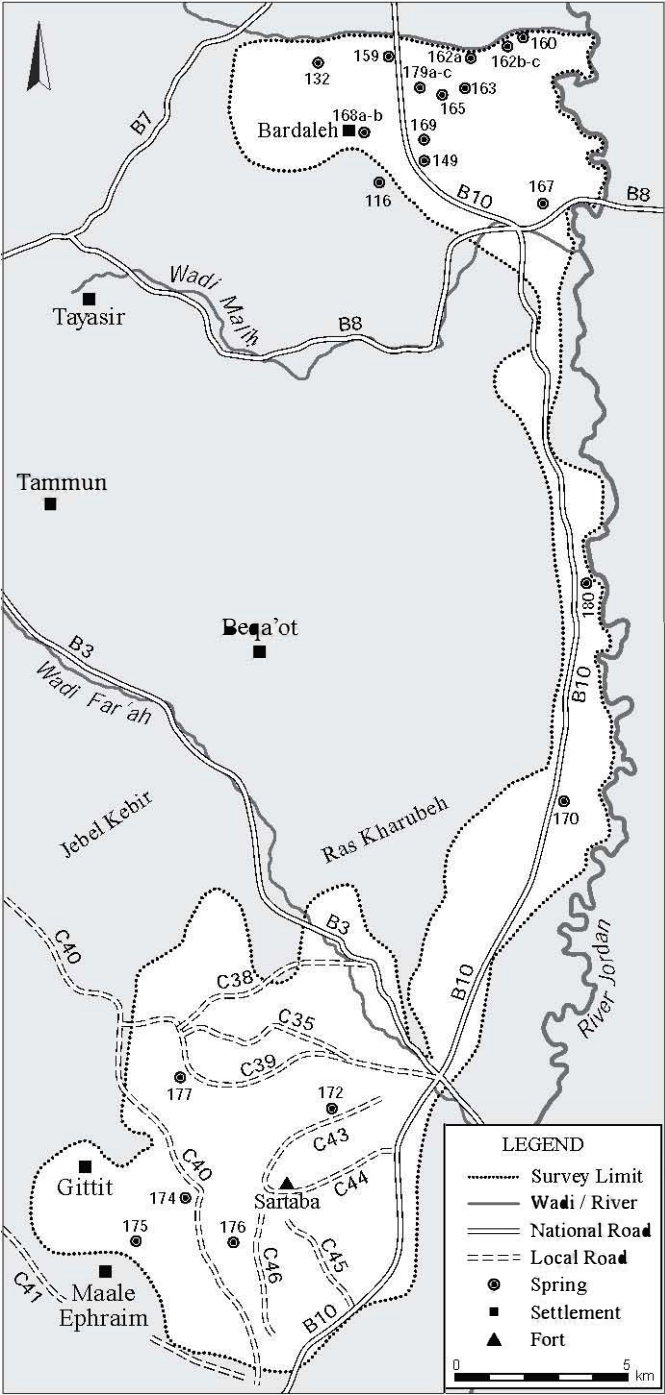
In the narrow Jordan Valley there is no flowing water and arable land is scarce; therefore the savannah and Sudano-Dickan vegetation grow together.

In contrast, in the Sartaba range a Mediterranean borderland floral community dominates, together with Irano-Turanian flora. The vegetation here is herbal without trees (Sabah 1992: 50). The sole plant to reach the dimensions of a small tree is the Jujube. Also found here are communities of White Broom (*Retama reatem*), *Artemisia Sieberi*, Sharp Varthemia (*Chilliadenus iphionoides*) and various species of Germander (*Teucrium* spp.).

4. Roads

4.1 Roman Roads

The good state of preservation of the Roman roads results from the sparse settlement in the desert fringes, the aridity and the infrequent human activity. This situation is similar to that in the Negev and the eastern Jordan Valley (for a general review see Roll 1976). With the increase of settlement, the advancement of agricultural development and fortification-building by the army in recent decades, many of the remains of Roman roads have been destroyed. Despite the good state of preservation, the Roman roads have been only superficially investigated. Conder and Kitchener first included them on their maps in 1870-1880. The roads were still visible during the British Survey, also by Glueck, and



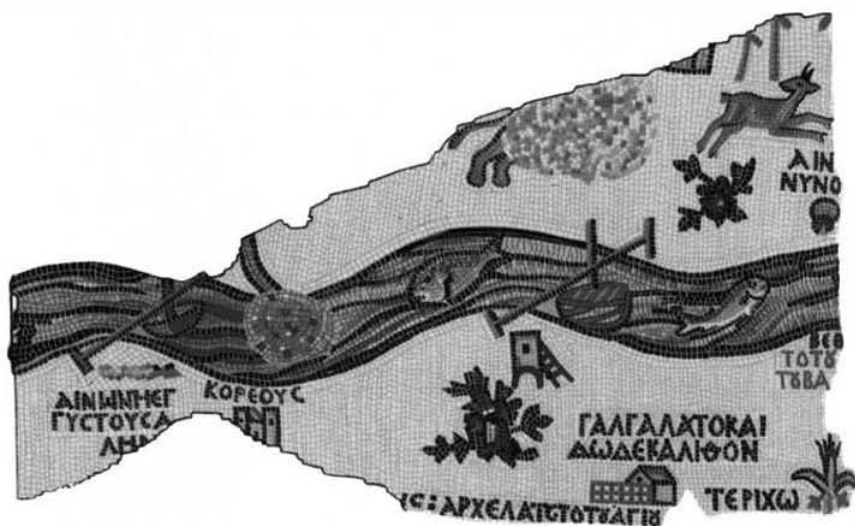
8. Map of the borders of Volume 4 and the main roads and springs, with their serial numbers.

even at the time of the Emergency Survey (1967). From 1973 to 1975 Ilan and Damati (1975) conducted a partial survey of Roman roads in the vicinity of the Sartaba. Some were recorded, and several sites near them were noted. Others (for example Dorsey 1991) summed up data without exploration in the field. In the case of Dorsey, the Iron Age sites found in the Emergency Survey were connected to each other by straight lines, creating a very illogical web of roads.

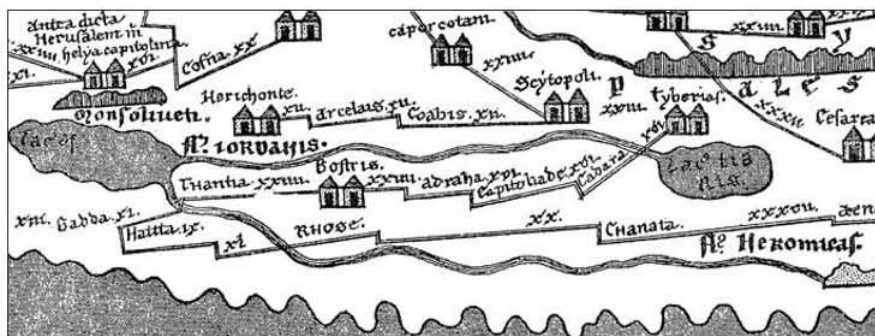
The roads:

1. The best known Roman road leads from Beit She'an to Jericho (B1● according to our terminology). Avi-Yonah (1963: 91), who relied on Thomsen (1917: 73), suggested that the road was paved in the time of Hadrian. Along it, north and south of Beit She'an, were found several milestones (Tzori 1962: sites 109-125): one from the reign of Caracalla, and the rest from that of Marcus Aurelius. In the area of our survey, south of Nahal Bezeq, some 8●● m south of Tirat Zvi, 11 fragments of milestones with remains of inscriptions have been found: one inscribed IMP C---/ANTONI/FE---/BRIT, and another -NINO---/A-O CKYOO-/VI (Tzori 1962: site 118). Mittmann (197●: 151) published a milestone (without inscription) found in a field, 1.5 km west of Khirbet es-Sakut (coordinates 1974/2●●2), where the tenth mile marker from Scythopolis was supposed to have been.

The road from Beit She'an to Jericho has been discussed several times (Mittmann 197●: 151; Zertal 1991). Several forts were found along it. It could be that the road appears in the Madaba Map (Avi-Yonah 1953: pl. 5), in which are shown the settlements of 'Einim near Shalem', 'Coreae', 'Phasaelis' and 'Archelais'.



g. The Madaba Map - the area of our survey (Avi-Yonah 1953: pl. 5).

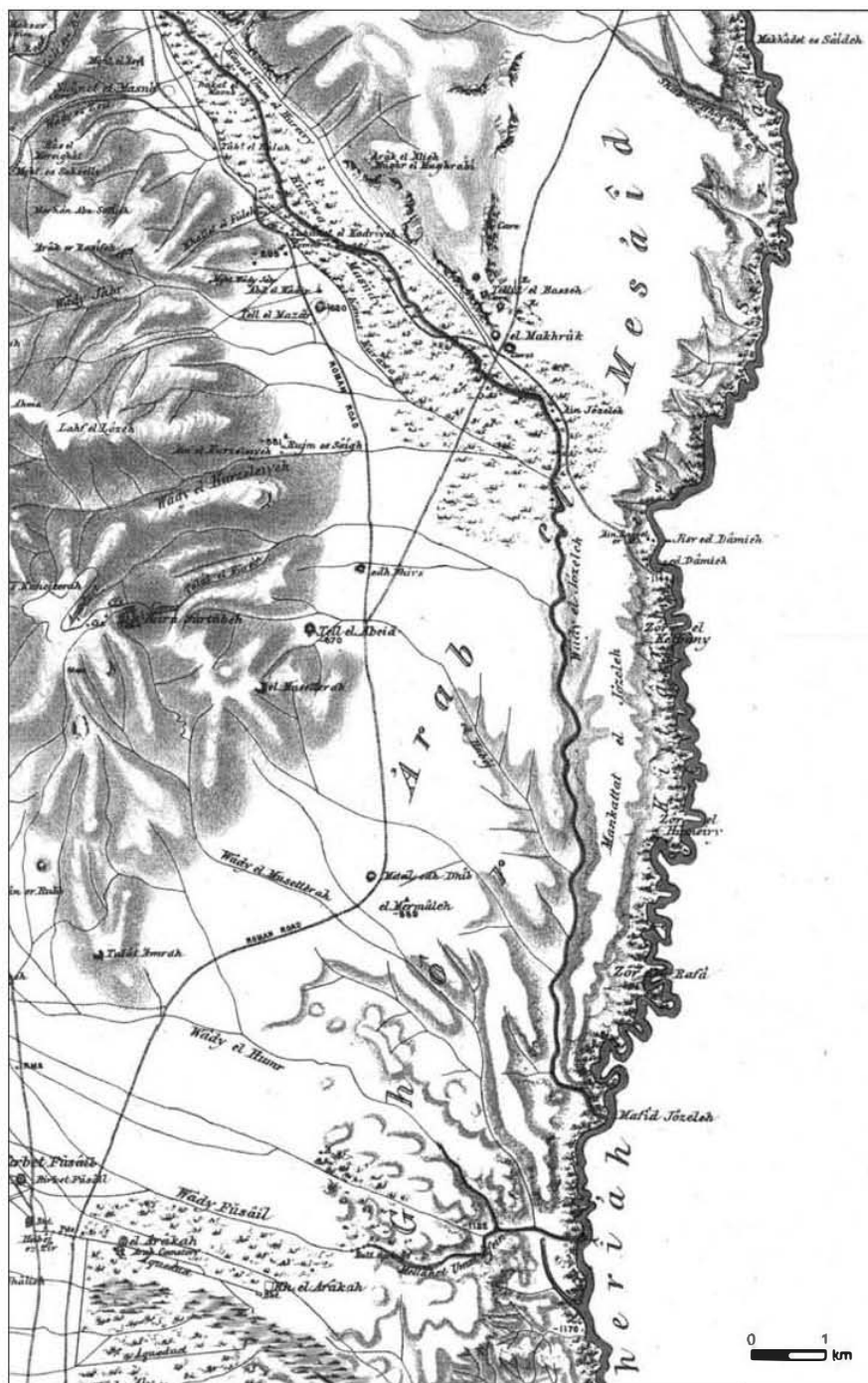


10. The Peutinger Map - the road from Scythopolis to Herichonte (Jericho) and the region of the Survey (Miller 1962: Segmentum X: 1-2).

In the Peutinger Map (*Tabula Peutingeriana*) the road is in three sections, with two stations (Ilan 1973: 149). Coabis is the first station, 12 Roman miles south of Beit She'an (Scythopolis). The next station is Archelais, 12 miles from Coabis. The third leg from Archelais to Jericho is also 12 miles. This means that the total distance is 36 Roman miles, about 53 km. All stations, apart from Coabis, have been identified with varying degrees of certainty. Zertal (1991: 13) has suggested identifying Coabis at 'Iraq Abu Hashish (A)' (Zertal 2008: site 248) or in Kh. Khiraf (Zertal 2008: site 266). The stations in the map seem to be fortified posts, and likewise have been found in both sites. The site at Kh. Fusayil was surveyed in 2000 (Zertal 2012a: site 34), and it was established that there also is a fort of the same type, thus somewhat strengthening the identification of the stations as forts.

In the map of the British Exploration Fund (sheet XV) the road from Beit She'an more or less follows the route of the existing road to the Valley Monument. Glueck found the remains of the road, close to Kh. es-Saleh, in 1943 (Glueck 1951: 420). The road is up to 6 m wide at this point. In the Emergency Survey, next to the Valley Monument, Bar-Adon (1972: site 14) traced a section of the road, and described it as follows "Remains of a Roman road, marked in the maps, on its sides two forts: one north of the road and the second at its south". Despite our search, some 35 years after the Emergency Survey, we have failed to find this road.

2. The road from Beit She'an (Scythopolis) to Shechem (Neapolis). This section of the road (B7 – according to our terminology – Zertal 2008: fig. 8) runs next to Tell Qa'un (Site 3), and from there to the entry to Wadi Shubash (Ilan 1973: 150). The road was published in the British Survey (Conder and Kitchen 1882), by Thomsen (1917: 70-72), Avi-Yonah (1963: 88) and others. It was also discussed in our Volume 2 (Zertal 2008: 28). Several milestones were found along it, close to Nahal Bezeq (Tzori 1962: site 113), and identified by us.



n. The SWP Map (sheet XV) including the Sartaba range and eastern Wadi Far'ah.

Within the bounds of our survey, Thomsen noted the following stones: no. 248 – south of Kh. Qa'un, with the inscription: IMP CAES IVLIO MAXIMINO PIO; no. 249 – the XXth mile from Neapolis, with the inscription: CAES C IVLIO UERO MAXIMINO P FEL AUG MANOCOMAX I MAXIMO NOBILISSIMO CAES FIL EIUS. Some of the milestones bear inscriptions from the reigns of Marcus Aurelius (162 C.E.) and Caracalla (211-217 C.E.). In the biography of the monk Sabas (Ilan 1973: 150) this road is mentioned as the 'King's Highway'. No remains of the road close to Qa'un were actually found.

3-5. The roads from Jericho to Shechem (Neapolis), have been noted as roads 1 and 2 in Ilan and Damati's survey (1975: map in p. 44), and C40 and C41 in our survey. From Jericho the road goes north in a straight line to Kh. Fusayil (Zertal 2012a: site 34). A fine description of this section appears in the SWP report: "The Roman road is very perfect near this ruin; it consists of three parallel lines of stones, about 1 foot square, forming the sides and central rib of the road, 9 feet apart, giving 18 feet for the width of the road. There seems to have been no foundation or drainage, but the central rib is higher than the sides, so that the road had a section of two inclined planes. The part between the ribs is filled in with a sort of cobble of stones of irregular size, covered with smaller metalling. The central rib consists of two lines of stones, the other wall, or curb-stone, of a single line each side" (Conder and Kitchener 1882: 392-393).

At Kh. Fusayil the road branches into two: one (our C40, Ilan and Damati's 2) ascending north-north-west, via the Wadi Ahmar valley, reaching the vicinity of 'Ein Hāfireh. Here it turns north-west towards Wadi Zamur and climbs to Neapolis via Sahel Afjeam, Wadi Kard and Ṭana et-Tahta. The leg ascending from Wadi Ahmar, over a narrow ridge to the site E.P. 150, deserves particular attention. Here, in the south-eastern part of the Sartaba range, the Roman road is well preserved. This section, measured and registered, received a special site number – 177 – in this volume. No additional remains have been discerned in the continuation of this section to the north-west. A very long stretch of this road has also been preserved to the east of the large site at Kh. Ṭana el-Foqa (Bar and Zertal 2016: 29-30).

The other branch (C41, Ilan and Damati's no. 1) ascends north-westwards from Kh. Fusayil over the ridge and south to Maale Ephraim, until just before the village of Majdal Bani-Fadel. The road passes close to Rujm Abu Mukheir (Bar-Adon 1972: site 10; Zertal 2012a: site 5); a section of which appears in Bar-Adon's round fort plan and is still visible. This branch ascends to 'Aqraba, and from there to Neapolis.

6-9. The roads from the Damia Bridge (the Jiftlik) to Shechem (Neapolis). This is the principal road (B3 in our terminology), by which Vespasian descended from Neapolis to Korai (War I, vi: 5), along Nahal Tirzah.

The three other roads recorded in the survey connect the Jordan Valley (the Jiftlik area) with Neapolis via Kh. Ṭana et-Tahta (Bar and Zertal 2016: 27-32). These roads are:

- Road C38, which ascends to the Es-Sawaneh plateau via Wadi ez-Zeith, connecting to C35 near Wadi edh-Dhba'ah' (3) (Site 131). The road's remains have not actually been found, but various clues, mainly the settlement model, hint at its existence.

- The second road (C35) ascends from the east to the 'Iraq er-Resifeh plateau. From there it runs along the northern crag of the ridge of the Sartaba, via the sites of Jebel el-Maḥjarah (5) (Site 139) and El Mureighat (E.P. 280) (Site 133). Then it reaches Wadi edh-Dhba'ah' (3) and connects to road C38, and afterwards to road C40. In these areas, sections of the road and sites built along it have been preserved. Most are forts containing fortified towers with adjoining courtyards.

- C35 and C38, joining C40. A section of this road has been preserved in the saddle near E.P. 236 (a small fort, Site 119), sloping sharply downwards to the Alon road. From here it ascends directly in Wadi Kabi to Kh. Ṭana et-Tahta.

- The next road is C39, which ascends Wadi Jaber westward to 'Ein Abu Daraj. A fine stretch of this road has been preserved next to the Lahmeh Complex (Site 155), and from here it continues west to Kh. Ṭana et-Tahta.

4.2 Other Roads

1. The road from Beit She'an to Jericho (B10 in our terminology) is not mentioned in the Bible. The district is part of the Biblical Arabah (Deut 3: 17; 11: 30, etc.), but the expression 'The Arabah highway' (II Sam 4: 7; Jer 39: 4) probably refers to the road from Jerusalem to Jericho and to roads on the eastern side of the Jordan. Aharoni (1979: 57-58 and map 3) mentions a road west of the Jordan parallel to the one on the eastern side; however, we failed to find any literary mention of it. Possibly, the pair of oval Iron Age II forts which have been discovered above the road on the east side of the Sartaba (Sites 98, 99), are connected to this road. It is difficult to interpret these forts without a context to the Beit She'an-Jericho road; it is interesting that Iron Age pottery was also found in Kh. Beiyudhat (Archelais) (Zertal 2012a: site 111), located further south along the road.

The main north-south longitudinal road probably passed along the eastern side of the Jordan. That side, abundant with water and agricultural land, was always more populated than the narrow arid western side (Mazar 1986; Aharoni 1979: 57-58). Due to the fact that the eastern side is much wider than the western one, the routes of the roads are more convenient.

Most of the Biblical roads mentioned in this volume are transverse